

■ By Amitabh Srivastava

It's a good time to be the progeny of a legislator in India. Being a politician's son or daughter brings with it many perks, not the least of which is the exclusive use of a new, expensive, state-of-the-art laptop. Many state legislatures have provided MLAs and MLCs with laptops—to encourage e-governance and give them an effective tool to track developments in their constituencies—but only a minuscule number actually use these for their intended purpose.

Most of the MLAs confess that such technology is beyond their comprehension. To get over this handicap, some legislatures arranged training courses but only a handful bothered to attend these. Instead, they passed the computers on to their children.

In West Bengal, where comrades take pride in their intellectual credentials, MLAs and ministers were given high-end Internet-ready Dell D630s only last year and were trained for two weeks, but to no use. E-mails sent to Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya and the state information technology minister did not yield a single response, a sign perhaps that they don't access their computers, quite unlike former president A.P.J. Abdul Kalam who has a personal website and answers every query that comes his way. In Kolkata, ministers Ashok Bhattacharya and Abdur Rezzak Molla say they find it "difficult to carry it around every day as it is heavy and likely to get misplaced".

Across the country, there are similar tales of non-use or misuse of laptops provided to MLAs, a proof that the exercise is a colossal waste of public funds. In Andhra Pradesh, Chief Minister Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy and Assembly Speaker K.R. Suresh Reddy had decided to give laptops to all 294 members late in 2006, but not more than 20 of them use it today. All legislators collected them within three weeks of the offer and even attended the training classes. The HP laptops—Wi-Fi-enabled, Bluetooth-integrated, five-in-one facility comprising telephone, scanner, printer, copier and fax machine—were to provide a virtual office on the move.

It has since been extended to 84



THE E-LITERATE CLAN

Legislatures spend crores of rupees every year to make MLAs e-friendly but it looks like money down the drain as few even bother to learn the basics

members in the 90-seat Andhra Pradesh Legislative Council also. During his tenure, former chief minister N. Chandrababu Naidu, now the Opposition leader, had initiated a scheme to give computers to MLAs provided they chipped in a third of the Rs 60,000 cost. The scheme was called off after several legislators collected the two-thirds from the government and then forgot all about the computer.

The scheme came a cropper though many legislators collected the grant. "The initial enthusiasm has not yet sparked the imagination of the legislators," admits Reddy who also has a rare

distinction of having his own website.

Laggard Bihar was one of the last states to embrace the laptop *raj*. Barring Chief Minister Nitish Kumar who is said to be tech-savvy, his palm-top-toting deputy Sushil Kumar Modi and Disaster Management Minister Nitish Mishra, no other legislator in the state Assembly seems to have the slightest clue about computers. The reason is not far to seek. When the other state governments were introducing e-governance, the then chief minister Lalu Prasad Yadav kept mocking at information technology. It wasn't until his daughter married a